Britta Lundin's Debut Novel, 'Ship It,' Is 'Really Gay'

And we are *very* excited.

By Tasha Cerny MAY 1, 2018

BRITTA LUNDIN/BRIANNA ELLIS-MITCHELL

For anyone who loves the show "Riverdale" enough to dive into the world of online fandom – which, let's be real, is most of "Riverdale"'s following – Britta Lundin is probably a familiar name. She's written on the CW show since 2017, and now, she can add YA author to her resume: Her debut novel "Ship It," named after the concept of fans cheering for two characters to get together in some (usually romantic) way, comes out today. The book follows Forest, an actor on a failing supernatural drama in need of more fans, and Claire, a teen fanfiction writer who desperately wants Forest to unpack and unlearn his assumptions about sexuality — mostly, his own character's. The story follows their blossoming friendship (and a romance for Claire) as they work together to boost the show's lagging popularity.

Lundin was already a celebrity in online fanfiction circles, where she'd grown up writing her own "X-Files"-inspired tales. "Some of the first fanfic I wrote was in middle school, about Scully chasing down ghosts and demons," she says. She devoted all that time to existing worlds and characters for a simple reason. "Fanfic remains the place where you can get some of the most prolific and diverse fiction about queer characters anywhere," Lundin says. "'Ship It' is sort of my ode to the wonderful queer writing that happens in fanfic, and a plea for film and TV to follow suit."

I sat down with Britta to discuss "Ship It," her passion for creating queer characters and identities, and what it's like writing for TV and traditional publishing at the same time.

Tasha Cerny: Congratulations on your first novel! That's a huge deal — how are you feeling?

Britta Lundin: This book is very personal to me, and for that reason I didn't think it would ever see the light of day. I thought it was too specific, too gay. (It's really gay.) But that's what made me want to write it in the first place, and I just hope it resonates with people.

TC: What do you mean by "too specific?" Who did you feel like you were writing this for?

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BL: As someone who is both in fandom and works in the entertainment industry (at the time I started writing it, I was an aspiring TV writer and got staffed [on "Riverdale"] during the writing process), I felt like I could write from both sides of the fandom divide. I wanted to try to explain why in my life, TV shows and specific [relation]ships have had an outsized importance to me. But I also have seen the other side of the coin, where sometimes fans are misunderstood or dismissed by those in the industry, especially when it comes to fans who shipnon-canon queer pairings. So this book came out of a desire to help both sides understand each other a little better.

TC: The book focuses on LGBTQ relationships in a time when the demand for representation is increasing. Do you see a great need for more stories involving LGBTQ youth?

BL: For sure. The good news is we're seeing wonderful, complex, and fresh LGBTQ stories being told more than ever before, but it's still not enough. One thing I love about young adult fiction is reading all the different queer books that are coming out right now, from contemporary to fantasy to historical, fluffy to angsty, funny to tragic. I'd love to see the writers and execs of more mainstream movies and broadcast TV shows embrace these stories too, by optioning YA books, or as my character Claire would want me to say, by looking to the characters they previously maybe assumed were straight, and asking themselves whether that character could be queer instead. It's easier than you think to improve representation in media. Just make 'em gay, y'all.

TC: "Ship It" originated as a feature script, correct? How did it evolve into the YA novel it is now?

BL: Yeah! I wrote it as a screenplay first, never imagining it could be a book, but then the very cool people at Freeform Books approached me because they had read and loved the script and thought it might make a great YA novel. I had never written fiction before (outside [of] fanfiction) but I loved the idea, so I wrote up the first few chapters for them as a sample. They loved it, so we moved forward. And now, I'm so excited it's coming out as a book because the world of YA is so welcoming. I've been able to meet other LGBTQ YA authors and join this community of writers who are all supporting each other.

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TC: You're also a staff writer on "Riverdale." What's it like trying to jump between writing for television and writing a book?

BL: They're very different experiences. The great part of being in a TV writers' room is the collaboration, and getting to sit down and figure out problems together instead of being all on your own, banging your head against a wall, like when you're writing a book. The flip side of that is, when I'm writing my book, I'm the boss in charge of all the decisions, so there's a lot of fun creative freedom with it that you don't get when you're just one person on a bigger team. They're both fun and satisfying in different ways.

TC: On "Riverdale," you're mainly telling stories from a teenager's perspective – do you prefer to write for a younger audience?

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BL: There's value in stories about people of all ages, but there is something special about writing about and for teenagers. I remember how difficult and isolating that time in your life can be, and I hope that my work helps teenagers (particularly queer teenagers) feel a little less alone.

TC: Take us through your journey as a writer. How did you go from writing your original "Ship It" script to getting staffed on a show?

BL: I had written a bunch of scripts before "Ship It." And when I started working on "Ship It'" I really had to convince myself it was a good idea. A script about gay fanfiction? Did I really want that to be my calling card? Did I really want to sit down in meetings with old Hollywood execs and agents and start explaining how John and Sherlock (from the BBC's "Sherlock") are actually in love? But the story spoke to me, so I wrote it. Ironically, it was the script I was most afraid of writing, but it was the one that people responded to the most. "Ship It" was also my writing sample for "Riverdale," and then it sold as a YA novel, all in the space of a few months. It was really an example of how one great script that resonates with people can launch your career. Writing the personal thing that scares you the most is sometimes the best career move you can make.

TC: Do you feel, as a writer, woman, and member of the LGBTQ community, that things are changing or improving on and off screen?

BL: It feels like things are improving sometimes, but then you look at the numbers, and every year it seems like the diversity report comes out and we've only made very small gains, if any at all. So there's still a long way to go.

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"Ship It" is available in bookstores today.

Tasha Cerny is a writer, social media manager, and contributor to The Tracking Board. Follow her @TLCerny.

This interview has been edited and condensed.

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